SEO Tools, Client Hunting and Productivity

A complete course for building a career in Search Engine Optimisation

For learners with basic computer knowledge who want to become SEO specialists, freelancers or agency staff.

13 chapters · 2 appendices · practical exercises in every chapter

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How to Use This Course

This course is written for a learner who can use email, a web browser and a spreadsheet, but who has never worked in SEO. It takes you from the first idea of what SEO is to the point where you can audit a website, fix its problems, report results and win paying clients.

Suggested study plan

Phase	Chapters	Time	Goal at the end
1. Foundations	1 to 4	2 weeks	You understand search engines and have your toolset ready.
2. Practical SEO	5 to 9	4 to 6 weeks	You can research keywords, audit a site and report results.
3. Business	10 to 13	4 to 6 weeks	You can run your productivity system, find clients and price your work.

Plan about 6 to 8 hours of study each week. Do the practice exercise at the end of every chapter before moving on. Learning SEO is practical: reading alone is not enough.

> **Practice site**
> Create a free personal website, a blog on a free platform, or use a small site you own. You will make real changes to it, so you learn by doing without risking a client's business.

> **Important note on tools and prices**
> Software prices, features and menus change often. The prices given in this course are approximate, and the menu names may differ slightly from what you see. Always check the official website before buying.

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CHAPTER 1

Introduction to SEO and the Career Path

Learning objectives. After this chapter you will be able to explain what SEO is, describe the work an SEO specialist does, and choose a realistic first career path.

1.1 What is SEO?

Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) is the practice of making a website easier for search engines to understand, and more useful for the people who search. When a website ranks higher in search results for the words people type, it receives more visitors at no cost per click. Those visitors can become customers, readers, subscribers or patients.

SEO is not a trick. Search engines want to show the most helpful pages. A good SEO specialist helps a site be found, understood and trusted, and helps the site owner remove the barriers that stop it from ranking.

1.2 Why SEO is a good career

- **Demand is steady.** Almost every business with a website needs organic traffic, and many small businesses have never had their site checked.
- **Measurable results.** You can show clients exact numbers: search impressions, clicks, positions and enquiries.
- **Low startup cost.** Most core tools are free. You can start with a laptop and a good internet connection.
- **Flexible work.** SEO can be done remotely, as a freelancer, inside a company, or in an agency.
- **Skills grow with AI.** AI tools help with drafting and data work, but clients still need people who understand strategy, data and trust.

1.3 Types of SEO work

Area	What you do	Typical output
Technical SEO	Make sure search engines can crawl, render and index the site fast and without errors.	Audit report, fix list for developer
On-page SEO	Titles, headings, text, images and internal links for each page.	Optimised page copy and metadata
Content SEO	Plan and write pages that answer what people are searching for.	Content calendar, briefs, articles
Off-page and authority	Earn trustworthy links and mentions from other sites.	Outreach plan, link list
Local SEO	Get local businesses found in Google Maps and local search.	Google Business Profile setup, citations
Reporting	Measure results and explain them clearly.	Monthly dashboard and summary

1.4 Career paths

Path	Who it suits	How to start
Freelance SEO specialist	Self-motivated people who like sales and variety	Work with 3 to 5 small clients, price per project and monthly retainer
SEO executive in an agency	People who want a salary, team and mentoring	Apply with a portfolio and a sample audit
In-house SEO for a company	People who like one brand and long projects	Move from content or marketing roles into SEO
Content or SEO writer	Strong writers who like research	Combine writing samples with keyword research
Technical SEO or analyst	People who enjoy data, code and spreadsheets	Learn HTML, basic JavaScript, Search Console API and Looker Studio

1.5 The SEO working cycle

Every SEO project follows the same cycle. Keep this cycle in mind through the whole course.

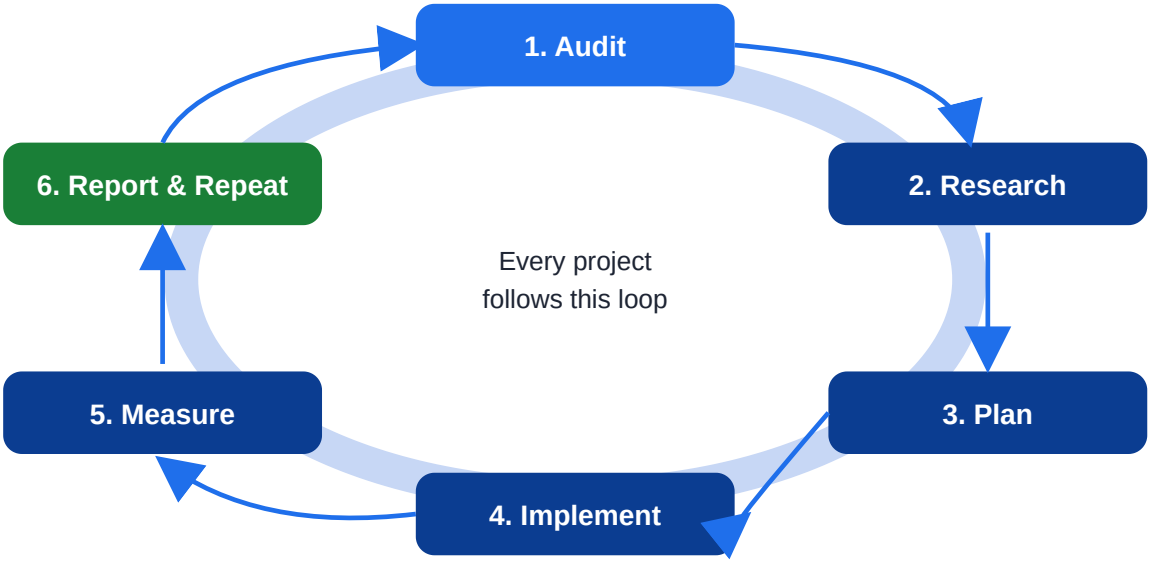


Figure 1.1 — The SEO working cycle

CHAPTER 1 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Pick three websites you visit often (for example a news site, an online shop and a local business). Write one thing you think each site does well for search, and one thing you think could be better.
2. Search for a product or service in your city. Note which results appear first and whether they are ads, maps, videos or ordinary links.
3. Write one paragraph: which career path from table 1.4 interests you most, and why.

Summary

SEO improves how a site is found and understood. It follows a repeated cycle of audit, research, planning, implementation, measurement and reporting. There are several career paths, and most people start as freelancers or junior staff.

CHAPTER 2

How Search Engines Work

Learning objectives. Explain crawling, indexing and ranking; describe what a search results page contains; and name the main quality signals search engines use.

2.1 Three steps: crawl, index, rank

Search engines such as Google and Bing do three main jobs for every page they know about.

1. **Crawling** — automated programs (Googlebot for Google, Bingbot for Bing) visit pages by following links and reading sitemaps.
2. **Indexing** — the search engine processes the content of the page, understands its topic and stores it in a huge database called the index.
3. **Ranking** — when someone searches, the engine picks matching pages from the index and orders them by relevance, quality and usability signals.

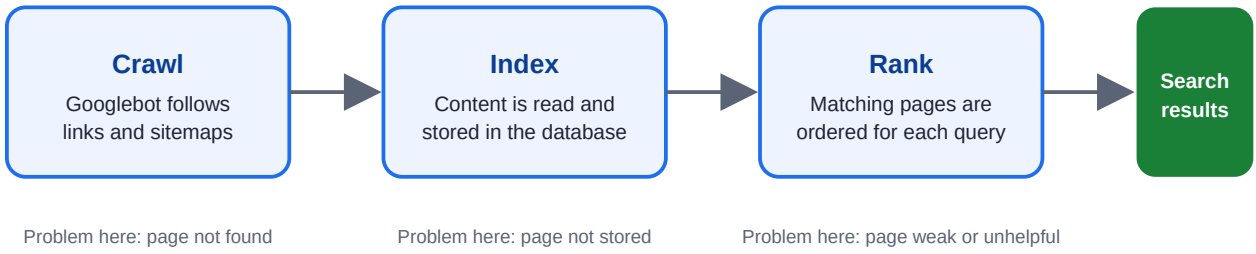


Figure 2.1 — From a published page to a search result

Most SEO problems fall into one of these three stages. If a page is not crawled, it cannot be indexed. If it is not indexed, it cannot rank. If it ranks but gets no clicks, the title or description may be weak, or the page may not match what people want.

2.2 What is on a search results page?

A modern results page (SERP) may show paid ads, a map pack for local businesses, featured snippets, images, videos, "People also ask" boxes and AI-generated summaries, followed by organic links. As an SEO specialist you need to know which of these your client can appear in.

2.3 Anatomy of a search snippet

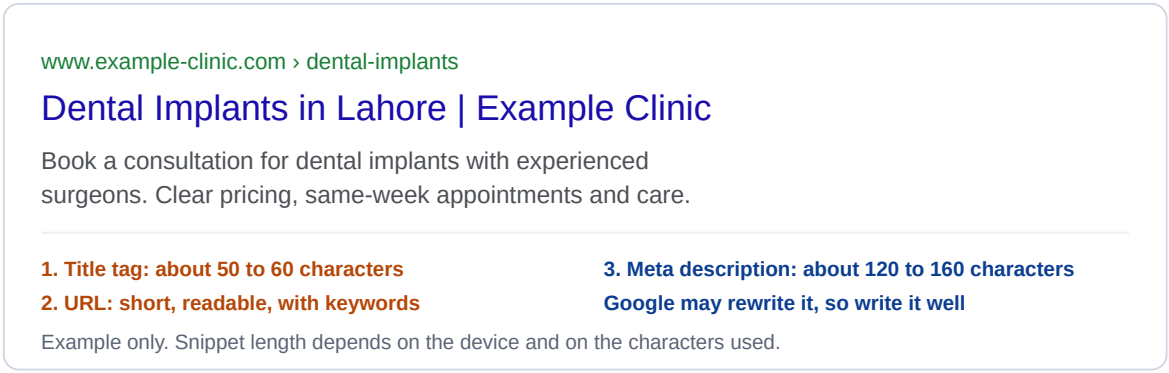


Figure 2.2 — The parts of a search result you control

2.4 Signals that matter (in plain language)

Search engines use hundreds of signals. Nobody outside the search companies knows all of them, and they change constantly. The main groups you should understand are:

Group	Examples	Plain meaning
Relevance	Keywords in title and text, topic match	Does the page match what the person typed?
Quality and trust	Expertise, author information, reviews, links from respected sites	Is this source reliable?
Experience	Core Web Vitals, mobile use, secure HTTPS, no intrusive pop-ups	Is the page pleasant to use?
Context	Location, language, device, search history where allowed	Is this useful for this person right now?
Content satisfaction	Answers the question fully, no need to search again	Did the page solve the problem?

> **Be careful with promises**
>
> No honest SEO specialist can guarantee a number-one ranking. Google's published guidance says that there is no shortcut. Be wary of anyone who promises guaranteed results or sells "secret" links.

2.5 Google's guidance: the rules to follow

- Write for people first. Search engines follow the same goal: useful, original content.
- Follow the Google Search Essentials (formerly called the Webmaster Guidelines). These describe what is allowed.
- Avoid spam practices: hidden text, doorway pages, scaled low-quality content, buying links that pass ranking value.
- Show experience, expertise, authoritativeness and trust (E-E-A-T). For health, finance and legal pages this matters even more.

CHAPTER 2 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Search for "best coffee shop in [your city]". Describe what the map pack shows and which websites appear in the organic results.
2. Open the Google Search Essentials page and list five rules you could explain to a client.
3. Open the source of one website (right-click, View Page Source). Find the title tag and the meta description.

Summary

Search engines crawl, index and rank pages. Titles, descriptions, helpful content, trust and page experience all influence results. Always follow the search engines' published rules.

CHAPTER 3

Hardware: Building Your Workstation

Learning objectives. Choose a computer, internet connection, screens and backup setup that suit SEO work and your budget.

3.1 Why hardware matters for SEO

SEO work involves a lot of browser tabs, large spreadsheets, website crawls that can run for hours, and video calls with clients. A slow or unreliable computer wastes your time, and a crawl that fails halfway can waste a whole afternoon. You do not need a gaming machine, but you do need a dependable one.

3.2 Recommended specification

Component	Minimum (starter)	Recommended (working professional)	Why
Processor	4 cores (for example Intel Core i3/i5 or AMD Ryzen 3/5, recent generation)	6 to 8 cores (Core i5/i7 or Ryzen 5/7)	Crawlers and browsers use several cores at once
Memory (RAM)	8 GB	16 GB or more	Many browser tabs plus a crawler plus spreadsheets
Storage	256 GB SSD	512 GB or 1 TB SSD	Crawl files, exports and screenshots take space
Screen	14 to 15 inch laptop display, 1920 x 1080	24 inch external monitor, 1920 x 1080 or better, plus laptop	Two screens let you see the crawler and the spreadsheet together
Internet	10 Mbps download, stable connection	20 Mbps or more, plus a mobile data backup	Video calls, large downloads and uploads of reports
Webcam and microphone	720p webcam, built-in microphone	1080p webcam, headset with a boom microphone	Clients judge professionalism by sound quality
Power backup	Power bank or laptop battery of 6+ hours	UPS (uninterruptible power supply) for desktops; laptop battery health checked	Protects against sudden power cuts that stop crawls and calls
Backup storage	Free cloud storage (Google Drive)	External 1 TB drive plus cloud backup	Client files are valuable; losing them damages trust
Mobile test device	Any modern Android phone	One Android and one iPhone (or borrowed for tests)	You must check how sites look on real phones

3.3 Layers of your workstation

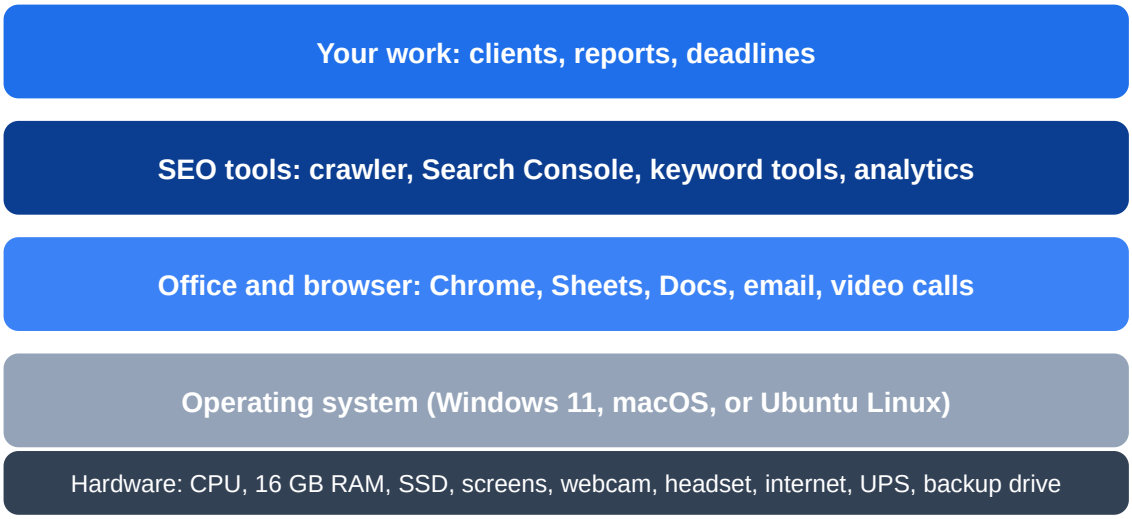


Figure 3.1 — The workstation stack, bottom to top

3.4 Three budget levels

Level	Suggested setup	Good for
Starter	Used or refurbished laptop with 8 to 16 GB RAM and SSD, headset with microphone, mobile hotspot backup, free cloud storage	First clients, learning, small audits
Working	New laptop 16 GB RAM, 512 GB SSD, 24 inch monitor, 1080p webcam, headset, UPS for desktop, 1 TB external drive	Regular clients, daily crawls, reports
Professional	Desktop or high-end laptop 32 GB RAM, two monitors, dedicated internet line, tested phones, quiet office, ergonomic chair	Agency work, many clients, large sites

3.5 Workspace and health

- Set up a quiet, private corner for client calls. Use a plain background or a tidy shelf.
- Keep your screen at eye level and about an arm's length away. Take a short break every 45 to 60 minutes.
- Use a chair with back support. Long sessions of crawl analysis are sitting work.
- Check your connection speed monthly at a site such as the official speed test in your browser or your provider's website.

CHAPTER 3 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Open the Task Manager (Windows) or Activity Monitor (macOS). Record your RAM, CPU and storage. Compare them with table 3.2.
2. Run a speed test three times at different times of day. Write down the average download speed.
3. Write your own budget for the Starter level. Include a note on what you will upgrade first.

Summary

A reliable computer with enough memory, a stable internet connection, a good headset and a backup plan are the foundation. Buy for reliability first, then upgrade screens and performance as your income grows.

CHAPTER 4

Software: Your SEO Toolset

Learning objectives. Install and set up the free SEO tools, understand what each one does, and decide when a paid tool is worth buying.

4.1 The toolset by job

Do not try to learn every tool at once. Each job in the SEO cycle has a core tool and a few helpers. The table below is the minimum toolset for a beginner. Every tool named here is covered in detail in Part 2.

Job	Core tool (free)	Helpers	Paid option (optional)
Accounts and data from Google	Google Search Console	Bing Webmaster Tools	—
Traffic and conversions	Google Analytics 4 (GA4)	Google Tag Manager	—
Keyword research	Google Keyword Planner, Google Trends	AnswerThePublic (limited free)	Semrush, Ahrefs, Ubersuggest, Moz Pro, Mangools
Site crawling and audit	Screaming Frog SEO Spider (free up to 500 URLs)	Chrome DevTools, Lighthouse	Screaming Frog licence, Sitebulb, Semrush Site Audit
Speed and experience	PageSpeed Insights, Lighthouse	WebPageTest	—
Structured data	Rich Results Test, Schema Markup Validator	JSON-LD generator tools	—
Local SEO	Google Business Profile	Google Maps, local citation checkers	BrightLocal, Whitespark
Backlinks and competitors	Ahrefs Webmaster Tools (free for your own verified site)	Open Site Explorer alternatives, Bing data	Ahrefs, Semrush, Majestic
Content writing	Google Docs, Hemingway Editor, Grammarly (free tier)	Surfer SEO, Clearscope, Frase	Surfer SEO, Clearscope
Reporting	Google Looker Studio, Google Sheets	Canva for charts	Agency Analytics, AgencyAnalytics
Productivity	Google Calendar, Notion or Trello, Google Sheets as CRM	Calendly, Loom, Zapier	ClickUp, Monday.com, HubSpot CRM (free tier)
Prospecting	Google Maps, LinkedIn (free)	Hunter.io and Apollo.io (free tiers)	LinkedIn Sales Navigator, Apollo paid

> **Paid tools: check prices yourself**
> Paid SEO platforms often cost from about USD 100 per month for a single user and more for larger plans. Many offer a free trial or a lower-priced plan for beginners. Check the current price and the usage limits before you commit.

4.2 Set up your accounts first

1. Create one Google account for work (for example `yourname.seo@gmail.com`), separate from your personal account. Turn on two-step verification.
2. Install Google Chrome and create a separate Chrome profile for each client. This keeps logins and history apart.

3. Create a folder structure in Google Drive: `Clients / [Client name] / Audits, Reports, Content, Invoices`.
4. Set up a password manager (for example Bitwarden, which has a free plan).
5. Create a business email address with your own domain when you start getting clients. A professional address builds trust.

4.3 Install and check the core free tools

GOOGLE SEARCH CONSOLE (GSC)

Search Console is Google's free tool that shows how your site performs in Google Search. It is the most important free tool in SEO.

- Go to search.google.com/search-console and add a property. Use the **Domain** option when you can; it covers all subdomains and protocols.
- Verify ownership with a DNS record (recommended), an HTML file, or a meta tag. Ask the client for access; never ask for their Google password.
- Give the client's web developer or your own account only the access they need. Use *Full* or *Restricted* permissions carefully.
- Submit the XML sitemap (for example `https://example.com/sitemap.xml`) from the Sitemaps report.

GOOGLE ANALYTICS 4 (GA4)

GA4 measures visitors, sessions, events and conversions. Universal Analytics stopped processing data in 2023, so all new setups use GA4. Set up a GA4 property, install the tag through Google Tag Manager or the site's own code, and mark important actions such as form submissions, phone clicks and purchases as *key events* (called conversions in older guides).

BING WEBMASTER TOOLS

Bing has a separate index and a share of search traffic that many businesses ignore. Import your Search Console site into Bing Webmaster Tools with one click, then check its reports.

PAGESPEED INSIGHTS AND LIGHTHOUSE

Enter any page address at pagespeed.web.dev to get lab and field data on speed and Core Web Vitals. Lighthouse is built into Chrome DevTools (press F12, open the Lighthouse tab) and gives the same kind of report locally.

SCREAMING FROG SEO SPIDER

Screaming Frog is a desktop crawler that visits each URL on a site and reports titles, meta descriptions, headings, status codes, redirects, images and links. The free version crawls up to 500 URLs; the paid licence removes this limit. Install it on Windows, macOS or Linux, and allow it at least 2 to 4 GB of memory for medium-sized sites (Configuration > System > Memory Allocation).

GOOGLE KEYWORD PLANNER AND GOOGLE TRENDS

Keyword Planner is inside Google Ads. You can use it without spending money by creating a Google Ads account and skipping the campaign setup. Google Trends shows relative search interest over time and by region; it is free and needs no account.

RICH RESULTS TEST AND SCHEMA MARKUP VALIDATOR

Use the Rich Results Test (search.google.com/test/rich-results) to check structured data for rich results. Use the Schema Markup Validator (validator.schema.org) to check any schema.org markup.

LOOKER STUDIO

Looker Studio (formerly Data Studio) is Google's free dashboard tool. It connects directly to Search Console, GA4 and Google Sheets. You will build client reports here in Chapter 9.

4.4 Paid tools: how to choose

Start with the free tools for your first three months. When you have a paying client who needs competitor research, large keyword lists or backlink data, consider one paid all-in-one suite. Compare:

- **Data quality for your target country and language.** Ask for a trial and test it on a keyword you know.
- **Crawling limits** and how many projects you can add.
- **Number of users and reports**, and whether you can export data.
- **Learning resources** and support. A tool you cannot use is wasted money.

4.5 Software security and privacy

- Never share a client's Google or hosting password. Use the platform's access sharing instead.
- Use two-step verification on every account.
- Do not install unknown browser extensions that ask for access to "all websites" unless you know the publisher.
- Keep client files separate. Delete temporary crawl exports when a project closes, after your client agreement allows it.

CHAPTER 4 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Create a Google Search Console property for a site you own (or a free test site) and verify it.
2. Install Screaming Frog and crawl your site. Note how many URLs it finds and whether any show errors.
3. Run PageSpeed Insights on your homepage and write down the mobile score and the three Core Web Vitals values.
4. Create a Google Sheet called "My Toolset" with one row per tool: purpose, cost, login email, date you last used it.

> **Summary**
>
> Start with Google Search Console, GA4, Screaming Frog (free version), PageSpeed Insights, Keyword Planner and Google Trends. Add one paid suite only when a real client need justifies it. Keep accounts secure and separate per client.

CHAPTER 5

Keyword Research

Learning objectives. Find, group and prioritise keywords for a business; understand search intent; and turn keywords into a page plan.

5.1 What is a keyword?

A keyword is a word or phrase people type into a search engine. In SEO a keyword is also the topic a page should target. Keyword research means finding which phrases people use, how often they search, how hard it is to rank, and how close they are to buying.

5.2 Search intent: the most important idea

Search intent is the reason behind a search. A page ranks only when it matches the intent. Always check the current results for your keyword before you write anything: if all the top results are product pages, a long blog article will struggle.

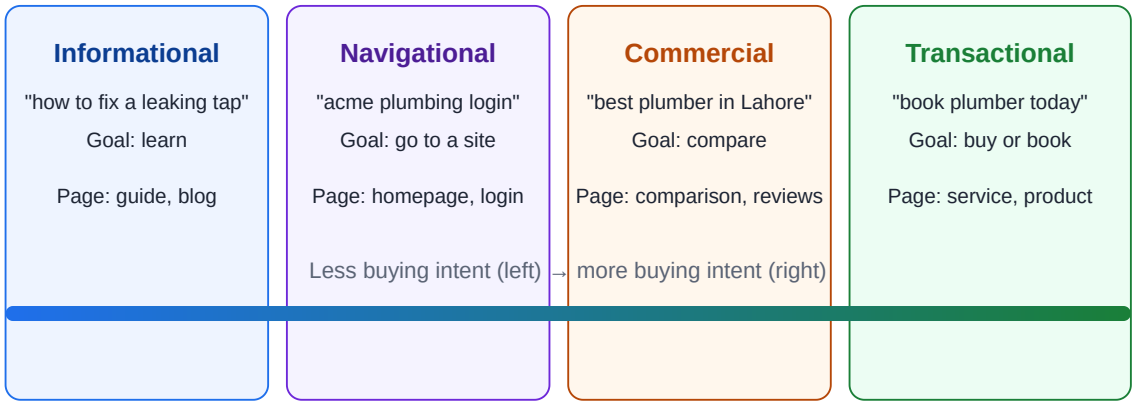


Figure 5.1 — Four types of search intent and the page each one needs

5.3 Keyword metrics you will see

Metric	Meaning	How to use it
Search volume	Average monthly searches in a country (an estimate)	Use as a rough guide; small businesses often do well with 10 to 500 searches a month
Keyword difficulty (KD)	A score from 0 to 100 of how hard it is to rank, based on the links of current top pages	Compare within one tool only; prefer lower scores for new sites
CPC (cost per click)	Average price advertisers pay for a click	High CPC suggests commercial value
Trend	Whether search interest is rising, stable or falling	Check Google Trends before investing in a seasonal topic
Intent	Informational, navigational, commercial or transactional	Match the page type to the intent
SERP features	Ads, maps, snippets, videos or AI overviews on the results page	Decide whether a page can realistically win a place

5.4 Step-by-step keyword research process

1. **Understand the business.** Ask the client: what do you sell, to whom, in which cities, and what is your best-selling service?
2. **Brainstorm seed keywords.** Write 10 to 20 phrases customers would use. Include the client's own words, competitors' names (for research only) and local terms.
3. **Expand the list.** Use Google Autocomplete (type the seed and read the suggestions), the "People also ask" boxes, the "related searches" at the bottom of results, and tools such as AnswerThePublic or your paid suite.
4. **Collect data.** Put all keywords into one Google Sheet. Add volume, difficulty, CPC and intent from Keyword Planner or your tool. Pull Google Trends for the top 10.
5. **Check the results.** Search each important keyword in an incognito window with the client's city set (or with a location setting in your tool). Note who ranks: big brands, directories, forums, or small local sites?
6. **Group keywords into clusters.** Keywords that share one search intent belong to one page. For example "dental implant cost", "how much are dental implants" and "dental implant price" usually share one pricing page.
7. **Map clusters to pages.** Create a keyword map: one row per URL, with primary keyword, secondary keywords, intent and priority.

5.5 Local and language considerations

- Search volume is per country and language. Set the correct country in every tool.
- Many people search in mixed languages or with spelling variants. Include them: for example "electrician near me", "electrician nearby", local spellings and transliterated words.
- For local businesses, include the city and nearby areas: "[service] in [city]", "[service] near [area]".

5.6 Worked example

A small clinic in a city wants more patients for dental implants. Seed keywords: "dental implants", "tooth implant", "implant dentist". Expanded list includes "dental implant cost", "best dentist for implants near me" and "is dental implant painful". Clusters: (1) service page for "dental implants [city]"; (2) price page for "dental implant cost"; (3) guide page for "is dental implant painful" (informational, to support the service page). Result: three planned pages, one service page with local keywords, and a list of questions for the content team.

CHAPTER 5 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Choose a business in your neighbourhood (or a friend's business). Write 15 seed keywords.
2. Expand them to at least 60 keywords using autocomplete and "People also ask". Put them in a Google Sheet.
3. Add intent to every keyword and group them into at least four clusters.
4. Create a keyword map with one row per planned page. Include the primary keyword, secondary keywords and priority (High, Medium, Low).

Summary

Keyword research means finding phrases, understanding intent, checking real results, clustering and mapping keywords to pages. Good research prevents you from writing pages that nobody will find.

CHAPTER 6

Technical SEO and Site Audits

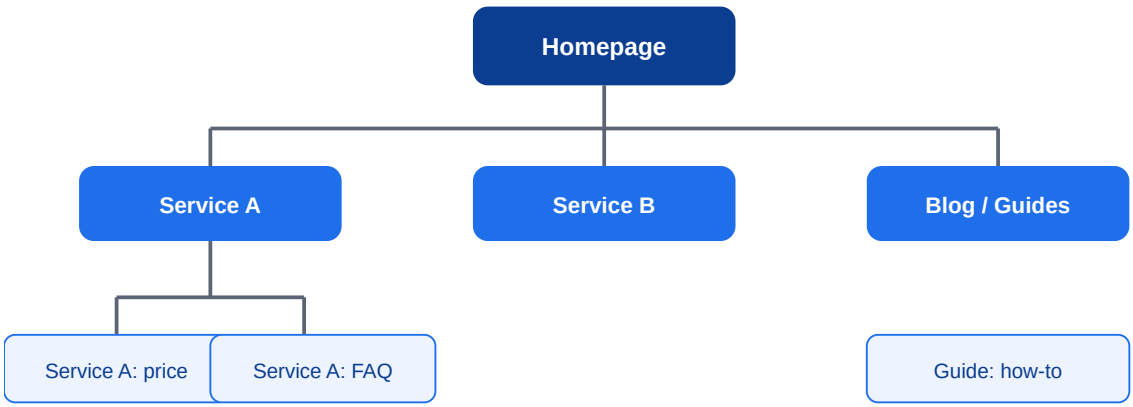
Learning objectives. Run a technical audit using Search Console, Screaming Frog and PageSpeed Insights; read the results; and write a prioritised fix list that a developer can act on.

6.1 What technical SEO covers

Technical SEO makes sure search engines can reach, read and store the right pages, and that the site works well for visitors. The main areas are:

- **Crawlability** — robots.txt, internal links, no crawl traps, correct server responses.
- **Indexability** — noindex tags used correctly, canonical tags, sitemap quality, duplicate content control.
- **Site structure** — clear categories, logical URLs, shallow depth (important pages within three clicks from the homepage).
- **Performance** — Core Web Vitals and mobile speed.
- **Security and errors** — HTTPS everywhere, no broken links, correct redirects, no mixed content.
- **Structured data** — schema markup that describes the business, products, articles or FAQs.

6.2 Site architecture



Good: clear levels, every page reachable in 3 clicks, links between related pages.

Figure 6.1 — A simple, crawlable site structure

6.3 Core Web Vitals

Core Web Vitals are Google's user experience measures. Check them in PageSpeed Insights and Search Console (Experience > Core Web Vitals). The three metrics are:

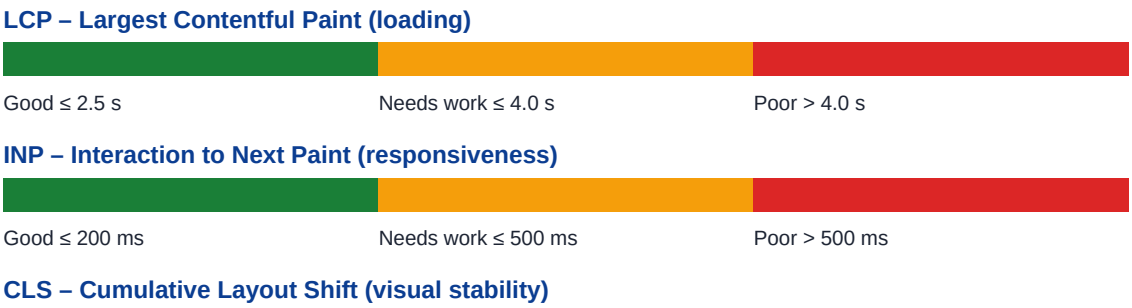


Figure 6.2 — Core Web Vitals thresholds at the 75th percentile (Good / Needs improvement / Poor). CLS: Good ≤ 0.1, Poor > 0.25.

INP replaced the older First Input Delay (FID) measure in March 2024. Thresholds are assessed on the 75th percentile of real visits, so check field data (real users) as well as lab data (a test run).

6.4 Step-by-step technical audit

STEP 1 — GATHER ACCESS AND CONTEXT

Get Search Console access, GA4 access, the CMS login (through the client's developer or a shared account), and a list of the client's most important pages.

STEP 2 — REVIEW SEARCH CONSOLE

- **Pages report (Indexing):** note "Not indexed" reasons such as "Crawled – currently not indexed", "Duplicate without user-selected canonical", "Page with redirect" and "Not found (404)".
- **Sitemaps:** confirm the sitemap is submitted, fetched and contains the right number of URLs.
- **Performance:** review clicks, impressions, average position and CTR for the last 3 months, with queries and pages.
- **Experience:** Core Web Vitals and mobile usability issues.

STEP 3 — CRAWL WITH SCREAMING FROG

1. Enter the homepage URL and start the crawl. For large sites, set a limit or crawl sections.
2. Check the *Response Codes* tab: list all 4xx (broken) and 5xx (server) errors.
3. Check *Redirects*: look for redirect chains (more than one hop) and redirect loops.
4. Check *Page Titles*, *Meta Description*, *H1* and *Canonicals* tabs for missing, duplicate or too-long values.
5. Check *Directives* for pages marked noindex that should be indexed.
6. Check *Images* for missing alt text and very large file sizes.
7. Export each problem list to a spreadsheet.

STEP 4 — TEST SPEED

Run PageSpeed Insights for the homepage, one service page and one blog post, on mobile and desktop. Record the scores and the top three "opportunities" suggested.

STEP 5 — CHECK STRUCTURED DATA

Paste key page addresses into the Rich Results Test. Note errors (which block the rich result) and warnings (which are advisory).

STEP 6 — WRITE THE AUDIT REPORT

Group findings into three levels:

Priority	Meaning	Example	Typical deadline
Critical	Blocks crawling, indexing or the main conversion path	Whole site set to noindex; homepage returns 500	This week
High	Significantly limits rankings or user experience	Many broken internal links; slow mobile LCP on service pages	Within 30 days
Medium / Low	Improvement with smaller impact	Long titles; missing alt text on some images	Within 90 days

Every finding in the report needs four things: the problem, the evidence (a screenshot or a URL list), the exact fix, and who should do it.

6.5 Robots.txt, sitemaps and canonicals

- **robots.txt** lives at the root of the domain (example.com/robots.txt). It tells crawlers which folders to avoid. Do not block CSS or JavaScript that the page needs to render. Do not use robots.txt to hide pages from Google; use noindex for that.
- **XML sitemap** lists the important URLs you want indexed. Include only canonical, indexable pages with a 200 status code.
- **Canonical tag** (`<link rel="canonical" href="...">`) tells search engines which version of a page is the preferred one. Use it to handle duplicate versions, such as URLs with filter parameters.
- **Redirects:** use 301 (permanent) when a page has moved for good. Avoid chains. Update internal links to point to the final URL.

6.6 Structured data (schema) basics

Schema markup is code that describes your content to machines. The most common types for small businesses are `LocalBusiness`, `Organization`, `Service`, `Product`, `FAQPage`, `Article` and `BreadcrumbList`. Use JSON-LD format, placed in the page head or body. Google reduced the number of rich result types it shows (FAQ results are now limited to certain sites), so test before you promise results. Schema helps understanding, but it is not a guaranteed ranking boost.

> **Do not mark up hidden content**
> Schema must describe content visible to users on the page. Fake reviews or ratings are against Google's policies and can lead to manual penalties.

CHAPTER 6 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Crawl a site you have access to (your own or a free demo site) with Screaming Frog. Export the response codes and page titles.
2. Find at least three broken internal links and at least one redirect chain.
3. Run PageSpeed Insights on three page types and record the mobile LCP, INP and CLS.
4. Write a one-page audit with a priority table of at least five findings. Include the exact fix for each.

Summary

A technical audit checks crawling, indexing, structure, speed, errors and structured data. Use Search Console for what Google sees, Screaming Frog for what the site contains, and PageSpeed Insights for experience. Report findings by priority with clear fixes.

CHAPTER 7

On-Page SEO and Content Optimisation

Learning objectives. Optimise titles, descriptions, headings, text, images and internal links; plan and brief content; and check the quality of a page before publishing.

7.1 The on-page checklist

On-page SEO is everything you control on a single page. Work through this list for each important page.

Element	Guideline	Common mistake
Title tag	About 50 to 60 characters; primary keyword near the start; brand at the end	Same title on many pages; keyword stuffing
Meta description	About 120 to 160 characters; clear benefit and a call to action	Copy of the first paragraph; empty description
URL slug	Short, lowercase, hyphens, contains the main keyword	Random IDs or dates for evergreen pages
H1 heading	One per page; describes the page topic	Logo as H1; two H1s; H1 different from title for no reason
H2 and H3 headings	Organise sections; include related keywords naturally	Headings used only to style text
Body content	Answers the main question early; covers the topic fully; uses short paragraphs	Thin pages under 150 words; repeating the same phrase
Images	Descriptive file names; alt text that describes the image; compressed (WebP or optimised JPEG)	Generic names like IMG_0023.jpg; huge uncompressed images
Internal links	Link to related pages with descriptive anchor text	"Click here"; orphan pages with no links in
Call to action	Clear next step: call, book, request a quote	No contact details on the page
Trust signals	Author or business details, reviews, certifications, address and phone	No About page; anonymous advice on health or money

7.2 Anatomy of a well-optimised page

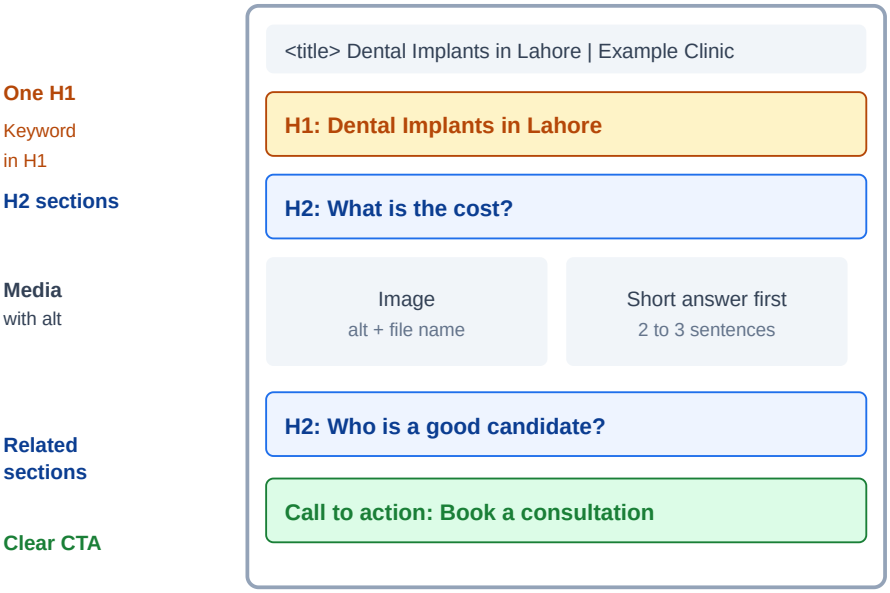


Figure 7.1 — Layout of a service page: one H1, supporting H2 sections, media with alt text and a call to action

7.3 Writing titles and descriptions

Write titles that a person would want to click. Use this pattern: *Primary topic – Benefit or qualifier* | *Brand*. Examples:

- "Dental Implants in Lahore: Costs, Process and Aftercare | Example Clinic"
- "Vegan Protein Powder Reviews 2026: 7 Tested Brands | Example Health"

Write descriptions as short promises with a reason to click: "Compare prices, see how long recovery takes and book a consultation this week."

> **Watch the year in titles**
> Titles with a year are useful for "best" or "reviews" pages, but you must update the year and the content every year. Do not put a year on evergreen service pages.

7.4 Content briefs and planning

A content brief tells a writer what to produce. A good brief includes:

1. Target keyword, secondary keywords and search intent
2. Audience and the problem the page solves
3. Working title and meta description
4. Suggested outline with H2 sections and the questions each must answer
5. Facts, sources and experts to include; claims that need verification
6. Internal links to add and pages to link to it
7. Word count range (a guide, not a target); example: 800 to 1,200 words for a service page with FAQs
8. Call to action and the business details to include

7.5 Writing for people and for search

- Answer the question in the first 100 words, then go deeper.
- Use short sentences and plain words. Aim for a reading age that a general audience can follow.
- Use bullet lists and tables where they help the reader compare.
- Show real experience: photos from the client's clinic or shop, case examples, and named staff with qualifications.
- Update old pages. Mark the last-reviewed date on guides where accuracy matters.
- Use AI tools only as assistants. Check every fact, price, medical or legal claim, and make sure the text sounds like the client.

7.6 Internal linking

Internal links help visitors move around and help search engines find and understand pages. Build a link plan: each service page links to its related guides and FAQs; each guide links back to its service page with a natural anchor such as "dental implant options"; the main menu and footer link to the most important sections.

CHAPTER 7 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Choose one page on a site you have access to (or write a practice page). Rewrite its title, meta description, H1 and H2 headings.
2. Write a content brief for one new page using the eight points in section 7.4.
3. Add three internal links to the page. Write down the anchor text you used and why.
4. Check the page with the on-page checklist in table 7.1 and list what you changed.

Summary

On-page SEO means clear titles, descriptions and headings, helpful content that answers the question early, good images, internal links and a clear next step. Good briefs help writers produce pages that match intent.

CHAPTER 8

Off-Page SEO, Link Building and Local SEO

Learning objectives. Explain how links and mentions affect authority; earn links ethically; set up and optimise a Google Business Profile; and manage local citations.

8.1 Links as votes of trust

A link from another website to yours is a signal that the other site trusts you. Search engines weigh links by the quality and relevance of the linking site, not just the number of links. Ten links from unrelated spam sites are worth less than one link from a respected local newspaper or industry association.

8.2 Ethical link building

Method	How it works	Risk level
Create useful resources	Publish a guide, calculator or data study that others naturally cite	Low
Digital PR	Offer journalists expert comments, original data or a story angle	Low
Partnerships and sponsorships	Support a local event, school or charity; ask for a link on their site	Low
Directories and associations	Listings in trusted industry directories, chambers of commerce, professional bodies	Low to medium (choose carefully)
Guest articles	Write an expert article for a relevant site with a clear editorial policy	Medium (avoid mass-produced guest posts)
Broken link building	Find broken links on relevant sites and suggest your page as a replacement	Low
Buying links, link farms, paid link networks	Pay for links that pass ranking value	High: against Google's policies; can cause penalties

Client protection

Do not build links that Google's guidelines prohibit. If a client asks you to buy links, explain the risk in writing and decline. You protect the client's long-term results.

8.3 Outreach email basics

- Find the right person (editor, webmaster, reporter) and personalise the first line with a specific detail.
- Offer something of value: a fact, a resource, a correction, an interview.
- Keep it short: four to six lines. Include who you are, the reason, and a clear question.
- Follow up once or twice after a week. Stop if the person says no.

- Follow spam laws in the countries you email (such as CAN-SPAM in the USA and GDPR/PECR in the EU and UK): identify yourself, provide a way to unsubscribe for marketing email, and respect opt-outs.

8.4 Local SEO and the Google Business Profile

Local SEO helps businesses that serve customers in a location. The most important tool is the **Google Business Profile** (GBP), which controls the business panel and map results. Use the official setup at business.google.com. The main factors Google describes are relevance (how well the profile matches the search), distance (how far the business is from the searcher) and prominence (how well-known the business is online, including reviews and links).

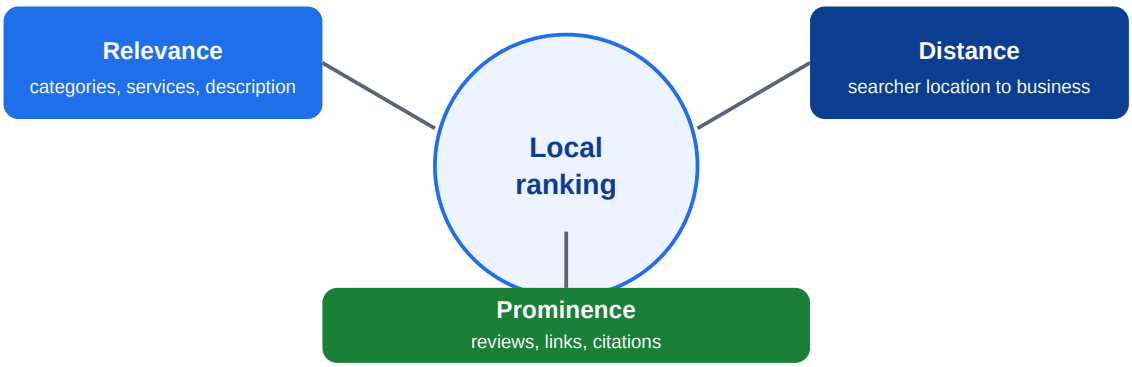


Figure 8.1 — The three factors behind local ranking

GOOGLE BUSINESS PROFILE CHECKLIST

☐ Use the real business name, address and phone number. Do not add keywords to the name (this breaks the rules).

☐ Choose the most accurate primary category and add relevant secondary categories.

☐ Add services, opening hours (including holidays), website link and appointment link.

☐ Upload real photos of the place, team and products. Add new photos monthly.

☐ Write a clear description that explains what the business does and where it serves.

☐ Ask happy customers for reviews. Reply to every review politely, positive or negative.

☐ Post updates or offers when they are relevant. Check the Insights report monthly.

☐ Keep NAP (name, address, phone) identical across the website, directories and social profiles.

8.5 Citations and directories

A citation is any online mention of a business's name, address and phone number. Core citations include Google, Bing Places, Apple Maps, Facebook, and national or local directories. Use a citation checker (for example BrightLocal or Whitespark, both paid) or search manually. Fix inconsistent details first, because mismatched data confuses search engines and customers.

8.6 Measuring link and local progress

- Use Ahrefs Webmaster Tools (free for verified sites) or the Links report in Search Console to track new and lost links.
- Track Google Business Profile performance: searches, views, calls, direction requests and website clicks.

- Track review count, average rating and response rate monthly.

CHAPTER 8 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Find a local business (a friend's shop is ideal). Search for its main service and record its position in the map pack and in organic results.
2. Use the checklist above to audit its Google Business Profile. List the gaps.
3. Find five relevant local directories or associations where the business could be listed. Write the NAP details you would use.
4. Write a short outreach email to a local newspaper or association offering a useful comment or resource. Keep it to six lines.

Summary

Links are earned through useful content and relationships, never bought. Local SEO depends on a complete, accurate Google Business Profile, consistent citations and genuine reviews.

CHAPTER 9

Analytics, Reporting and Dashboards

Learning objectives. Read Search Console and GA4 reports, set useful KPIs, and build a clear monthly client report in Looker Studio.

9.1 What to measure

Metric	Where it comes from	Why it matters
Impressions	Search Console	How often the site appears in results (visibility)
Clicks	Search Console	Visits from Google search
CTR (click-through rate)	Search Console (clicks divided by impressions)	Whether titles and descriptions attract clicks
Average position	Search Console	Average ranking; check per query and page, as it can mislead when averaged
Organic sessions and users	GA4 (Traffic acquisition report, filtered to Organic Search)	Visitors arriving from search
Key events (conversions)	GA4	Enquiries, bookings, purchases, calls
Engagement rate	GA4	Share of sessions that were engaged (replaces bounce rate in GA4)
Core Web Vitals	Search Console Experience report	Page experience health
Google Business Profile actions	GBP Insights	Calls, direction requests and website clicks from local search
Keyword rankings	Rank tracker in your SEO tool (optional)	Tracks chosen keywords over time

9.2 Read the Search Console performance report

1. Set the date range to the last 3 months and compare with the previous period.
2. Sort queries by impressions. Look for queries with many impressions but low CTR: these pages need better titles.
3. Look for queries ranking in positions 8 to 20 (page two). Small improvements can move them to page one.
4. Filter by page to see which URLs gain or lose clicks.
5. Use the "Compare" option to find pages with the biggest drop; check for technical issues, content changes or seasonal demand.

9.3 Build a monthly report in Looker Studio

Looker Studio is free. Create a report, add a data source for Search Console (choose the property and "Site impressions" or "Search Console" connector), a second data source for GA4, and a Google Sheet for manual notes or rank data. Use the template layout below.

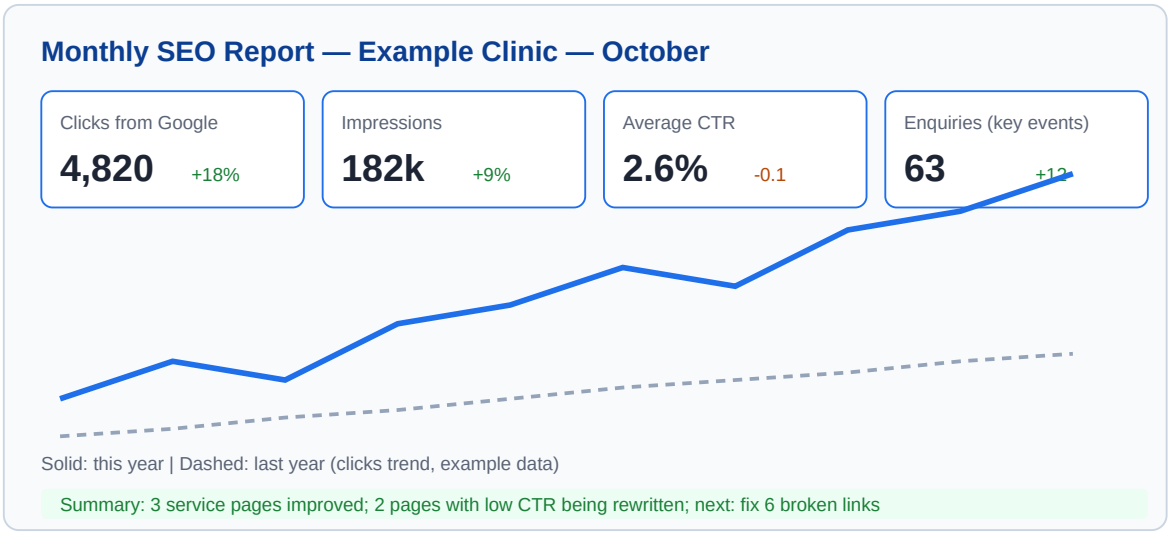


Figure 9.1 — Layout of a simple monthly client dashboard (example figures only)

9.4 A report structure that clients read

1. **Summary (one half page):** three wins, two concerns, and the plan for next month.
2. **Headline numbers:** clicks, impressions, CTR, enquiries, Google Business Profile actions, each with the change from last month.
3. **What changed:** the work completed this month, linked to the results where possible.
4. **Top pages and keywords:** the pages gaining the most, and the opportunities in positions 8 to 20.
5. **Technical health:** errors fixed, errors open, Core Web Vitals status.
6. **Next month's plan:** three to five actions with owner and date.

> **Be honest with data**
> Search Console data is delayed by about two days and some queries are hidden for privacy. Changes take weeks or months to show. Explain trends rather than blaming or praising one week of data.

9.5 Common analysis mistakes

- Judging SEO after two weeks. Most changes need at least 8 to 12 weeks.
- Comparing average positions across very different queries.
- Confusing impressions with visits.
- Reporting vanity numbers (for example total pages indexed) without business outcomes.
- Ignoring seasonality. Compare with the same month last year where possible.

CHAPTER 9 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Open Search Console for a site you can access. Find three queries with high impressions and low CTR, and write a better title for one page.

2. Connect Search Console and GA4 to a new Looker Studio report. Add a scorecard for clicks and a line chart for the last 16 weeks.
3. Write a one-page monthly summary following the structure in section 9.4.

Summary

Measure what matters to the business: visibility, clicks, engaged visits and enquiries. Use Search Console, GA4 and Looker Studio together. A clear, honest report keeps clients and builds your reputation.

CHAPTER 10

Productivity System

Learning objectives. Set up a task, time and client system that lets you manage several clients without missing deadlines; use AI tools safely to save time.

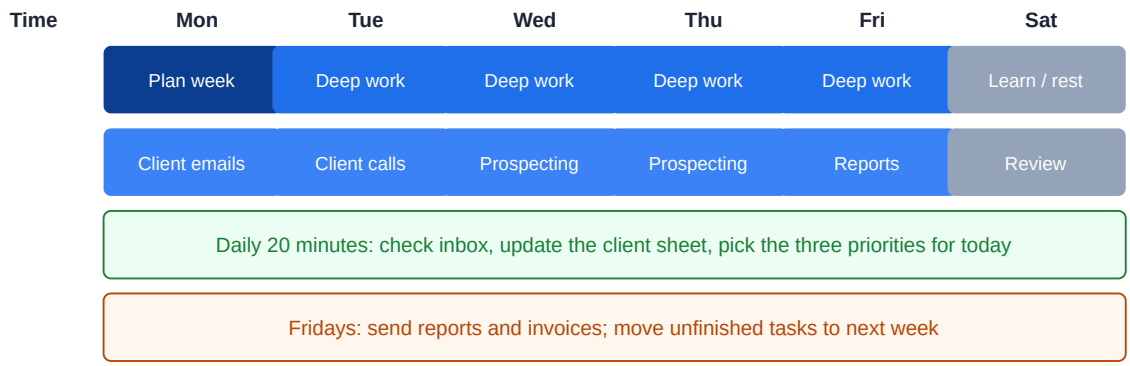
10.1 Why productivity matters in SEO

SEO work is made of many small, repeated tasks: checking rankings, writing titles, answering client emails, running crawls, building reports. Without a system, these tasks take over the week and the important strategy work never happens. A good system protects your deep-work time and makes every client feel attended to.

10.2 The core system: five tools

Purpose	Recommended tool	What you store
Calendar and time blocks	Google Calendar	Deadlines, client calls, deep-work blocks, reporting days
Tasks and projects	Trello (simple) or Notion / ClickUp (detailed)	One board per client; cards for each task with due date
Client records (simple CRM)	Google Sheets or HubSpot free CRM	Contacts, status, next follow-up date, value, notes
Documents and notes	Google Drive and Docs	Audits, briefs, reports, contracts, meeting notes
Reporting	Looker Studio and Sheets	Dashboards and monthly summaries

10.3 Weekly rhythm



Example layout. Adjust the times to your own energy and client needs.

Figure 10.1 — An example weekly rhythm for a freelance SEO specialist

10.4 Time-management methods

- **Time blocking:** put deep-work blocks (audits, writing, analysis) in your calendar first. Treat them like client meetings.
- **Pomodoro:** work 25 minutes, rest 5 minutes. Useful for crawl reviews and repetitive data work.
- **Batching:** answer emails at two set times a day, not after every notification. Prepare all client calls for one day when possible.
- **Eat the frog:** do the hardest, most valuable task first thing in the morning.
- **Weekly review (30 minutes, Friday):** review what was delivered, what slipped, and the plan for next week.

10.5 Templates to save time

Create these once and reuse them for every client:

- Audit report template (Google Docs) with sections for summary, findings, priorities and next steps
- Keyword map template (Google Sheets)
- Content brief template (Google Docs)
- Monthly report template (Looker Studio, duplicated for each client)
- Onboarding checklist: access needed, kick-off questions, first 30-day plan
- Email snippets for follow-ups, proposals and onboarding

10.6 Using AI tools well

AI assistants such as ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini can speed up brainstorming, drafting meta descriptions, summarising crawl exports, writing first drafts of outreach and explaining technical errors. Use them with these rules:

- Never paste client passwords, personal data or confidential financial information into a public AI tool. Check your client agreement first.
- Check every fact, statistic, price and legal or medical claim against an official source.
- Do not publish AI text without editing it for accuracy, tone and originality.
- Disclose AI use where clients or publishers require it.
- Keep a prompt library in your Notes app, with the prompts that work for your tasks.

CHAPTER 10 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Set up a Trello board (or a Notion page) with four columns: Backlog, This week, Doing, Done.
2. Create a Google Sheet CRM with columns: Business, Contact, Source, Status, Next follow-up, Notes.
3. Block four deep-work sessions in your calendar for next week and keep them for one full week.
4. At the end of the week, write a 10-line review: what worked, what did not, one change for next week.

Summary

A simple system of calendar, task board, client sheet, document folders and reporting keeps your work visible. Time blocks protect deep work. Use AI for speed but never for unchecked facts or confidential data.

CHAPTER 11

Finding Clients

Learning objectives. Define your ideal client, build a prospect list, make ethical outreach, use free audits as a door-opener, and track your pipeline.

11.1 Start with a niche and an ideal client

Beginners often say "I work with anyone". Clients prefer specialists who understand their business. Pick one of these starting points:

- **Local service businesses** in one city: dentists, clinics, lawyers, plumbers, salons, restaurants, schools, tuition centres, real-estate agents.
- **E-commerce shops** selling one category of product.
- **Bloggers or publishers** in one topic area.
- **Software or service startups** in one industry.

Write an ideal client profile: industry, size, location, typical budget, current problem, who makes the decision, and where they spend time online. Keep this profile in your CRM.

11.2 The client-hunting funnel

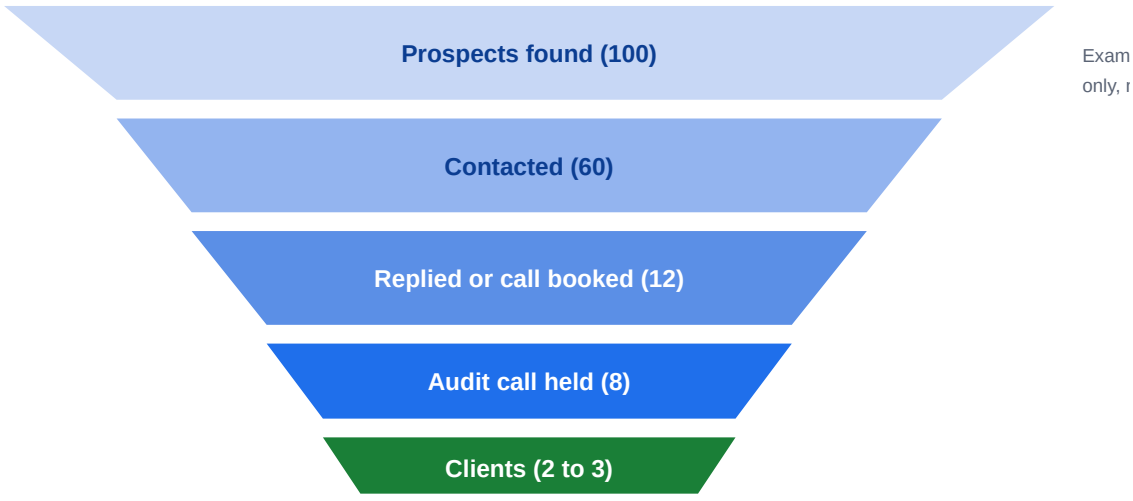


Figure 11.1 — A typical pipeline. Track your own numbers and improve the weakest stage.

11.3 Where to find prospects

Source	How to use it	Notes
Google Maps	Search "[business type] in [city]" and list businesses with websites	Free; the best source for local clients
Google Search	Search "[service] in [city]" and see which sites rank poorly; note their title and speed	Use it for research, not spam
LinkedIn	Search owners, marketing managers and clinic or shop managers; follow and comment before messaging	Sales Navigator is paid and adds filters
Business directories and chambers of commerce	Member lists and event attendee lists	Often include contact details publicly
Upwork and Fiverr	Look for SEO jobs and bid with a short, specific proposal	Good for first reviews; commissions and competition are high
Facebook and Reddit groups	Answer questions helpfully in local business and marketing groups; follow group rules	Do not spam group members with links or sales messages
Referrals	Ask past clients, friends, web developers and designers to introduce you	The most profitable source over time
Your own content	Publish a helpful article or LinkedIn post about a common local SEO problem	Builds inbound enquiries slowly but steadily

11.4 Build a prospect list

1. Create a Google Sheet with columns: Business, Industry, City, Website, Phone, Email (if public business email), Google rating, Obvious issue found, Source, Status, Next date.
2. For each prospect, spend five minutes checking: Is the site mobile-friendly? Does the title match the business? Is the Google Business Profile complete? Is there a contact form and phone number?
3. Record one specific, honest observation per prospect. For example: "Homepage title is only the business name; no service pages found; PageSpeed mobile score 34."
4. Only record contact details that are publicly listed for business purposes, and keep them in your private file.

11.5 Outreach that gets replies

Good outreach is short, specific and polite. It shows you have looked at their business and offers a clear, low-risk next step. Use the template below and personalise the bracketed parts. Do not send mass copies of the same email.

Template: first email

Subject: Quick observation about [business name]'s website

Hi [first name],

I was searching for [service] in [city] and noticed [specific observation, for example: your service pages do not show prices, or your Google Business Profile has no photos from the last year].

I help local [industry] businesses get more enquiries from Google. I put together a short, free review of [business name]'s search visibility. Would it be useful if I sent it over?

Best regards,
[Your name], [Your business name]
[Phone or website] · To stop receiving these emails, reply "no thanks".

Template: follow-up (sent 5 to 7 days later)

Hi [first name], following up on my earlier note. I have a three-point summary ready for [business name]: one quick win for your Google profile, one page title to change, and one speed issue to check. Happy to send it. Should I?

11.6 The free mini-audit

A free mini-audit is a one-page summary of 5 to 8 observations with the most visible issues and simple fixes. It shows your skill and gives the prospect something useful even if they do not buy.

- Keep it to one page and one hour of work.
- Use real evidence: screenshots, PageSpeed scores, title tags, Google Business Profile gaps.
- Include two quick wins they can do themselves and two bigger tasks you can offer.
- Do not invent problems or exaggerate. Honest audits build trust; false ones end careers.

11.7 Calls and discovery

Ask about goals before you talk about tools. Useful questions include: What is your most profitable service? Where do most enquiries come from now? What have you tried before for SEO? Who handles your website? What would a good result look like in six months? What is your budget range?

11.8 Compliance and ethics

- Follow anti-spam laws for email, and respect unsubscribe or "no thanks" replies immediately.
- Do not use other people's private personal data, do not pretend to be a client's staff, and do not impersonate Google or any official body.
- Do not promise guaranteed rankings or specific income figures.
- Do not bribe reviewers or ask customers to leave fake reviews.

CHAPTER 11 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Write your ideal client profile in 100 words.

2. Build a list of 25 prospects using Google Maps. Record the observation fields described in section 11.4.
3. Send five personalised first emails (or LinkedIn messages) and log them. Track replies for two weeks.
4. Prepare one mini-audit using the structure in section 11.6 for a business on your list.

Summary

Choose a niche, build a prospect list with real observations, reach out politely with a specific reason, and offer a free mini-audit as a helpful first step. Track every stage in a simple pipeline and improve the weakest one.

CHAPTER 12

Pricing, Proposals, Contracts and Delivery

Learning objectives. Choose a pricing model, write a proposal, understand the basic contract terms, and deliver an onboarding that sets up a successful client relationship.

12.1 Pricing models

Model	How it works	Good for	Watch out for
One-off audit	Fixed price for a written audit and fix list	New prospects; testing a relationship	Clients may not implement the fixes
Project	Fixed price for a defined scope, for example 10 optimised pages	Clear, bounded work	Scope creep; define exclusions
Monthly retainer	Recurring fee for an agreed set of tasks and hours or deliverables	Ongoing SEO; steady income	Define the deliverables; do not sell "unlimited" work
Hourly	Rate per hour, with time tracked	Consulting; uncertain scope	Clients may hesitate; slow for beginners
Performance-linked	Base fee plus a bonus for agreed results	Experienced specialists with strong data	Results depend on many factors outside your control

Prices vary widely by country, experience and the size of the client. As a starting point, many beginners price small local clients at a modest monthly retainer and raise prices as their results and reviews grow. Research what local agencies charge, then price for your time, skills and the value the client receives. Recheck your pricing every six months.

12.2 Simple price calculation

Work out your minimum monthly income, add tax and business costs, divide by the hours you can bill (not all your working hours are billable), and add a margin for growth. Example: you need 1,000 in monthly income, costs are 100, and you can bill 60 hours per month. Minimum rate = (1,000 + 100) / 60 = about 18.30 per hour. Price packages around that minimum plus value and experience.

12.3 Writing a proposal

1. **Their situation:** summarise what you learned in the discovery call, in the client's words.
2. **Goals:** three measurable goals (for example "increase enquiries from organic search by 20% in six months").
3. **Recommended scope:** the tasks, deliverables and timeline for the first 90 days.
4. **What is not included:** for example development work, paid advertising, content writing beyond agreed pages.
5. **Price and payment terms:** fee, billing frequency, payment method, and what happens if the client pauses.

6. **Reporting:** how and when you report, and which tools you use.
7. **Client responsibilities:** access, timely approval, and content or product details you need.
8. **Next steps:** a single clear action with a date, such as "sign and return by Friday to start on Monday".

12.4 Contracts and key terms

Use a written agreement for every paid engagement, even a small one. A good agreement includes:

- Parties, service description and deliverables
- Fees, payment dates, late-payment terms and currency
- Start date, duration, notice period for cancelling
- Access and data: who owns accounts, passwords and content; client keeps ownership of their website and data
- Confidentiality and what you may show in your portfolio (get written permission)
- Limitation of liability, and a clear statement that SEO results cannot be guaranteed
- Dispute process and governing law (use the rules of your country)

> **Get professional advice**
> This section is general information, not legal advice. For contract wording, ask a qualified lawyer in your country, or use a reviewed standard template from a professional association.

12.5 Invoicing and getting paid

- Send invoices on the same day each month, with clear payment terms (for example "due in 14 days").
- Use invoicing tools such as Wave (free for basic invoicing in some countries), Zoho Invoice or the invoicing tools in your payment platform.
- Ask for part payment in advance for projects, especially with new clients.
- Keep records of every invoice and payment for tax purposes. Ask a local accountant about tax registration and deductible business costs.

12.6 Onboarding: the first 30 days

Week	Actions	Output
Week 1	Kick-off call; get access; agree goals; set up Search Console, GA4, Google Business Profile access	Access checklist complete; shared project folder
Week 2	Full technical audit; keyword research; competitor check	Audit report; keyword map
Week 3	Agree priorities; developer tasks sent; first on-page changes	Priority list signed off; first changes live
Week 4	First monthly report baseline; set reporting schedule; review progress	Baseline dashboard; first client update call

12.7 Delivering value and keeping clients

- Respond within one business day, even if the answer is "I will reply by Thursday".
- Explain what you did and why in simple language. Clients judge value by understanding.
- Hold a short monthly call to review the report and agree next steps.
- Admit mistakes early and fix them quickly.
- Ask for a review or testimonial after a successful milestone, and ask for referrals.

CHAPTER 12 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Calculate your minimum hourly rate using the method in section 12.2 with your own numbers.
2. Write a one-page proposal for the mini-audit prospect from Chapter 11, including scope, exclusions and price.
3. Draft a checklist of contract terms from section 12.4, then ask a local professional to review the final agreement.
4. Create an onboarding checklist for the first 30 days.

> **Summary**
> Price for value and your minimum income. Use written proposals and agreements. Make onboarding structured so clients see progress from the first month, and report honestly.

CHAPTER 13

Your First 90 Days: Roadmap and Career Growth

Learning objectives. Follow a 90-day plan to become job-ready or client-ready, build a portfolio, and plan your long-term growth.

13.1 A 90-day roadmap

Period	Learning	Practice	Business
Days 1 to 30	Chapters 1 to 6; set up all free tools	Audit your own site; complete Chapter 5 exercises	Set up Google Business Profile for yourself; create a LinkedIn profile; choose a niche
Days 31 to 60	Chapters 7 to 9; learn Looker Studio	Optimise 3 pages on a practice site; build one dashboard	Build a prospect list of 50; send 20 personalised messages; deliver 2 free mini-audits
Days 61 to 90	Chapters 10 to 12; review and refine	Publish 2 case studies from your practice work	Land your first 1 to 3 paying clients or a job interview; refine prices and proposal

13.2 Build a portfolio

A portfolio proves your skill. Include:

- **Case studies** from practice or paid work: the problem, the actions, the results, and what you learned. Use real numbers only with permission.
- **Sample audit** (anonymised) and a sample monthly report.
- **Keyword map and content brief** samples.
- **Certificates** from recognised free or paid courses (for example Google's free digital marketing and Search Console learning resources), listed honestly.
- **Testimonials** with the client's name and permission.

Practice case study template

Client type: [local dentist, Lahore] · Problem: [no service pages, slow mobile speed] · Actions: [built three service pages, fixed 14 broken links, improved LCP from 4.2s to 2.3s] · Result: [organic clicks up 28% over 3 months] · Lesson: [service pages with clear prices converted better]. Be accurate; never invent results.

13.3 Learn continuously

- Read official sources first: Google Search Central documentation, Search Console Help, Bing Webmaster Guidelines, and GA4 help pages.
- Follow reputable SEO news sites and practitioners. Test claims on your own sites before repeating them to clients.
- Practise on new tools each quarter, but do not chase every trend.

- Keep a learning log: one page per month of what you tested and what happened.

13.4 Career milestones

Stage	Typical signs	Next step
Beginner	Can run an audit with guidance; knows the tools	Work on two practice sites and complete a case study
Practitioner	Runs audits and monthly reports alone; manages 2 to 5 clients	Improve content strategy and reporting depth
Specialist	Solves complex technical issues; teaches others; strong results	Specialise (for example e-commerce, local, or technical SEO)
Lead or owner	Manages a team, pricing and sales processes	Systemise delivery; hire and train

13.5 Avoid common career mistakes

- Taking every client, including those who want guaranteed rankings or spam links. Protect your reputation.
- Working without written agreements or without access controls.
- Ignoring the client's business goals and focusing only on rankings.
- Underpricing for too long and then being unable to raise prices.
- Burning out by working on too many clients at once. Keep your client load to a level you can deliver well.

CHAPTER 13 PRACTICE EXERCISE

1. Write your 90-day plan in a Google Sheet with weekly tasks and a check box for each.
2. Create one case study from a practice project using the template above.
3. Write your LinkedIn headline and about section in 120 words. Mention your niche, tools and the kind of help you offer.
4. Schedule a monthly review with yourself to check progress against the plan.

> **Summary**
> In 90 days you can build the skills, portfolio and first client pipeline needed to start. Keep learning from official sources, keep honest records, and grow from freelancer to specialist step by step.

APPENDIX A

Glossary of SEO Terms

Term	Meaning
Anchor text	The clickable words of a link
Backlink	A link from another website to yours
Canonical tag	Code that names the preferred version of a page
Citation	Online mention of a business name, address and phone number
Core Web Vitals	Google's user experience measures: LCP, INP and CLS
Crawl budget	How many pages a search engine will crawl on a site in a period; matters mainly for very large sites
CTR	Click-through rate: clicks divided by impressions
E-E-A-T	Experience, expertise, authoritativeness and trustworthiness: quality concepts in Google's guidance
Google Business Profile (GBP)	Free business listing that appears in Google Maps and local search
H1, H2, H3	Heading levels in HTML that show page structure
Index	The database of pages a search engine can return in results
Internal link	A link from one page of a site to another page of the same site
Keyword cannibalisation	Several pages of one site competing for the same keyword
Keyword difficulty	An estimated score of how hard it is to rank for a keyword
Meta description	Short summary of a page used in some search snippets
Noindex	Instruction telling search engines not to index a page
Organic search	Unpaid search results
Redirect (301, 302)	Sends visitors and search engines from one URL to another; 301 is permanent, 302 is temporary
Robots.txt	File that tells crawlers which parts of a site to avoid
Schema markup	Structured data code (schema.org vocabulary) that describes page content
Search intent	The goal behind a search: learn, go, compare or buy
SERP	Search engine results page
Sitemap	File listing a site's important URLs for search engines

Title tag	The page title in HTML, often shown as the blue headline in results

APPENDIX B

Checklists and Templates

B.1 New client onboarding checklist

- ☐ Signed agreement and first invoice sent
- ☐ Access to Search Console (owner or full user), GA4 (editor), Google Business Profile (manager)
- ☐ CMS access through the client's developer or shared login (no shared passwords in email)
- ☐ Kick-off call completed; goals written down
- ☐ Project folder created in Google Drive
- ☐ Baseline metrics saved (3 months of Search Console data, GA4 organic sessions, GBP insights)

B.2 Technical audit checklist

- ☐ Search Console: indexing errors, sitemap status, manual actions, Core Web Vitals
- ☐ Crawl: status codes, redirects, broken links, noindex, canonicals, titles, descriptions, H1
- ☐ Speed: mobile and desktop tests on homepage and top 3 templates
- ☐ Mobile: layout, font size, tap targets, intrusive pop-ups
- ☐ Security: HTTPS on all pages, valid certificate, no mixed content
- ☐ Structured data: Rich Results Test for main templates
- ☐ Robots.txt and sitemap reviewed
- ☐ Priority list written with owners and deadlines

B.3 On-page checklist (per page)

- ☐ Primary keyword and intent match the page
- ☐ Title 50 to 60 characters, unique
- ☐ Meta description 120 to 160 characters, unique
- ☐ One H1 with keyword; logical H2 and H3 structure
- ☐ Answer in first 100 words; helpful content with examples
- ☐ Images compressed, named sensibly, alt text added
- ☐ At least three relevant internal links in and out
- ☐ Clear call to action and contact details visible
- ☐ Author or business information and last-updated date where relevant

B.4 Monthly client report checklist

- ☐ Summary with three wins, two concerns and next month's plan
- ☐ Clicks, impressions, CTR, average position (with query and page detail)
- ☐ GA4 organic sessions and key events (enquiries)
- ☐ Google Business Profile actions and reviews
- ☐ Work completed this month with links to pages

☐ Technical issues open and closed

☐ Next month's actions with owner and date

B.5 Hardware and software purchase checklist

Item	Required?	Bought (date)	Notes
Laptop or desktop (16 GB RAM, SSD)	Yes		
Headset with microphone, webcam	Yes		
Internet plan (20 Mbps or more) and mobile backup	Yes		
External backup drive (1 TB) or cloud plan	Yes		
Second monitor (24 inch)	Recommended		
UPS for desktop	Recommended in power-cut areas		
Android phone for mobile testing	Recommended		
Google Workspace or free Google account set up	Yes		
Screaming Frog licence (when needed)	Later		Free version first
One paid SEO suite (when needed)	Later		Choose after a trial

B.6 Final course assessment

Before you start taking clients, you should be able to do all of the following without help:

1. Explain crawling, indexing and ranking in two minutes to a non-technical person.
2. Set up Search Console, GA4 and a Looker Studio report for a site.
3. Run a Screaming Frog crawl and identify the five most important technical problems.
4. Build a keyword map of at least 50 keywords grouped by intent.
5. Optimise a page's title, description, headings and internal links.
6. Audit a Google Business Profile and list the improvements.
7. Write a mini-audit and a proposal for a local business.
8. Write a monthly report that a business owner can understand.